

**Captain courageous:** Chamari Athapaththu, the experienced leader of the pack, is one of the last remaining members of a generation of experienced players who have slowly made their way out of the active playing system. ACC

way out of the active playing system. Those who've barely seen a few seasons were left in her care to try and carve out a framework that could work beyond her time on the field. It might sound reductive to say that Sri Lanka's chances began and ended at Chamari's feet, but it is a hard truth. For a long time, she carried this team on her back. Sri Lankan wins were automatic consequences of a good day in the office for the all-rounder.

Sri Lanka was tested only twice in this tournament — once in the semifinal against Pakistan and then against India in the trophy match. A Lankan chase was underway in both instances. Chamari set up the game in her team's favour but fell before the job was done and was forced to pace around the sidelines praying to every god she knew for her girls to see the win through. Anushka Sanjeevani and Achini Kulasuriya held their nerves to scrape through in the penultimate clash, but what unfolded in the final took that spirit a few notches higher. Sri Lanka managed to unlock a new gear, moving past survival to dominance.

When Chamari fell in the final, 72 runs were still needed off 48 balls. It was all starting to look all too familiar for the captain as she trudged up and down the dugout, dreading any déjà vu she might feel. But this is Chamari's Lanka. She has taught her kids well. Harshita Samarawickrama and Kavisha Dilhari did not bow down to an Indian side waiting to strike again. They took on Pooja Vastrakar and Radha Yadav with disdain, a raucous crowd perfectly scoring their exploits with rising decibel levels. A last-over finish

wasn't even needed. The pair saw Lanka through with eight balls to spare. Kavisha's war cry, Harshita inconsolable as she sank to the ground before being hounded by her teammates, players racing onto the field, a stoic Chamari wiping tears by the boundary — the scenes were picture-perfect.

The last year or so has been incredible for the Sri Lankan side. It won the qualifier for the T20 World Cup. The side beat Bangladesh, England, and South Africa (the last two were away fixtures) in T20Is. It beat New Zealand and West Indies in the ODIs. All of these brought with it an expanding pool of contributors to Sri Lankan victories, just what Chamari wanted all along.

The Asia Cup, Chamari's first major international title as skipper, will only strengthen the faith ahead of the World Cup in Bangladesh.

In a parallel universe, the script for this final had an India win. It was only logical. India was head and shoulders above the rest in quality, experience, and form. In a tournament where par scores of 130-140 would often be discussed, India was the side eyeing the 190s.

But when has sport ever been purely about logic? It needs heart. Sri Lanka's bowlers offered India its first proper challenge in the tournament,

asking probing questions to India's batting line-up. Sri Lanka's batters were easily the hardest India faced in the tournament. And when things got the slightest bit more uncomfortable, India panicked.

Fielding was a problem for Harmanpreet and co. throughout this tournament, and it came to bite India yet again in the final. Without regular successes, the bowlers strayed in their line and length. Harmanpreet herself was frantic in trying out as many options as possible to unsettle the Lankans, all in vain.

One can argue that a win here would have closed out India's preparations for the World Cup perfectly, but one must also agree that this loss will actually do some good than otherwise. It gave India a reality check — that form alone cannot win you games. Taking opponents lightly rarely pays off, and the biggest test of tactical acumen happens when you have to ditch your binder of plans and think on the go.

India's campaign was far from

**Perseverance personified:** Sri Lanka's long penance for the Asian crown had borne fruit on the nation's sixth attempt. ACC

